

Affect and effect

Teaching guide

Describe an influence and its result.

Understand the distinction

Affect is usually a verb meaning influence: The noise affected my sleep. Effect is usually a noun meaning a result or influence: The noise had an effect on my sleep.

There are less common meanings: effect can be a formal verb meaning bring about, as in effect change; affect can be a specialist noun about outward emotional expression. Start with the common patterns, but do not treat the spelling distinction as exceptionless. A causal claim still needs evidence.

Compare the patterns

VERB

The delay affected our plans.

Affected tells what the delay did.

NOUN

The delay had an effect on our plans.

Effect is the noun after an.

CAUTIOUS CLAIM

The delay may affect our plans.

May preserves uncertainty.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Complete: The weather can ___ travel.

2. Complete: What ___ did the change have?

3. Is effect never a verb?

Use it in your own life

Describe a possible influence without claiming certainty.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. affect

A verb is needed after can.

2. effect

This question asks about the result as a noun.

3. No. Effect change means bring change about.

That formal use is less common than the noun.

One possible response

The new timetable may affect my journey to work.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-38.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Ask learners to explain the differences between the comparison examples before reading the rules. Use their answers to identify the point that needs attention.

2. Explain and check (4 minutes)

Read the short explanation together. Keep its qualifications: a common pattern is not necessarily a rule for every context. Ask learners to give a counterexample where the lesson mentions an exception.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Describe a possible influence without claiming certainty.

Have learners work alone, then compare with a partner. Ask the partner to restate the intended meaning before suggesting a correction.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Use the answer explanations to review the three checks. Accept natural alternatives that preserve the intended meaning. Ask each learner to revise one sentence and identify the change.

Extension

Change the person, time, place, or purpose in a comparison example. Ask whether the original pattern still fits and why. Revisit one example in the next lesson.

Feedback criteria

Meaning: the message is understandable. Form: the target pattern fits the context. Transfer: the learner can use it in a fresh example. This short activity is not a proficiency certification.